

“Verily, the dawn of a new Day has broken. The Promised One is enthroned in the hearts of men. In His hand He holds the mystic cup, the chalice, of immortality. Blessed are they who drink therefrom!”

## **The Declaration of the Bab**

### **Part I: The Search**

“Great indeed is this Day! The allusions made to it in all the sacred Scriptures as the Day of God attest its greatness. The soul of every Prophet of God, of every Divine Messenger, hath thirsted for this wondrous Day. All the divers kindreds of the earth have, likewise, yearned to attain it...”

- Baha'u'llah

The Báb, Whose name was Siyyid ‘Alí-Muḥammad, was born on 20 October 1819 in Shíráz, a city in southern Iran, also known as Persia. Most of the people in Persia belong to a branch of Islám that awaits the appearance of a promised One of God called the Qá’im. The title “Qá’im” means “He Who ariseth”.

Among them was Siyyid Kázim, a saintly personage who lived in the city of Karbilá in ‘Iráq. Siyyid Kázim had many students, and he devoted his life to preparing them for the long-awaited advent of the Qá’im. He repeatedly told them that, upon his death, they should leave their homes and, with hearts free of all earthly desires, go forth in search of the promised Beloved.

After the passing of Siyyid Kázim, a most distinguished student of his, Mullá Ḥusayn, spent forty days in prayer and meditation, during which he opened wide his heart to God’s inspiration. He then left ‘Iráq with two companions and began his quest. He went first to Búshihr. He did not remain there long, however, for he felt pulled irresistibly northwards, towards Shíráz. As he approached the city, he asked his two companions to go to a certain mosque and to wait for him to join them there.

A few hours before sunset on that day, just outside the gate of Shíráz, he met a youthful Personage Who welcomed him and invited him to His home to refresh himself following his long and difficult journey. Mullá Ḥusayn was deeply impressed by the gentle yet compelling manner in which this extraordinary Youth spoke. He went with Him, and soon they arrived at the door of a modest house. They entered and proceeded to the upper room. The gracious Host ordered a water-jug to be brought so that His guest could wash away the dust from his travels. Then, He Himself prepared tea and offered it to Mullá Ḥusayn. After these acts of hospitality, He began to speak. The details of that historic conversation were later recounted by Mullá Ḥusayn:

## Part II: The signs of the Promised One

“It was about an hour after sunset when my youthful Host began to converse with me. ‘Whom, after Siyyid Kázim,’ He asked me, ‘do you regard as his successor and your leader?’ ‘At the hour of his death,’ I replied, ‘our departed teacher insistently exhorted us to forsake our homes, to scatter far and wide, in quest of the promised Beloved. I have, accordingly, journeyed to Persia, have arisen to accomplish his will, and am still engaged in my quest.’

‘Has your teacher,’ He further inquired, ‘given you any detailed indications as to the distinguishing features of the promised One?’

‘Yes,’ I replied:

- ‘He is of a pure lineage, is of illustrious descent, and of the seed of Fáṭimih.
- As to His age, He is more than twenty and less than thirty.
- He is endowed with innate knowledge. He is of medium height, abstains from smoking, and is free from bodily deficiency.’

He paused for a while and then with vibrant voice declared: ‘Behold, all these signs are manifest in Me!’ He then considered each of the above mentioned signs separately, and conclusively demonstrated that each and all were applicable to His person.” Additionally, Mulla Husayn had **two** standards by which he hoped to determine the truth of whoever claimed to be the Great Messenger

1. The first test was a treatise that Mulla Husayn had composed himself – it dealt with the obscure and difficult teachings of Shaykh Ahmad and Siyyid Kazim.
2. Whoever seemed capable of unravelling the mysteries of (1) would then be put to the test of commenting on the highly allegorical chapter of Joseph in the Quran.

“Will you,’ Mulla Husayn asked him, ‘read this book of mine, and look at its pages with indulgent eyes?’ The Bab graciously complied with this wish. He opened the book, glanced at certain passages, closed it and began to address Mulla Husayn. Within a few minutes, He had unravelled all its mysteries and resolved all the problems. He further expounded on certain truths which could be found neither in the reported sayings of the imams of the Faith nor in the writings of Shaykh Ahmad and Siyyid Kazim. He revealed, with astonishing rapidity, the first part of His commentary on the Súrih of Joseph, a significant chapter of the Qur’án.

### Part III: The Transformation

He then addressed Mullá Ḥusayn in these words:

“O thou who art the first to believe in Me! Verily I say, I am the Báb, the Gate of God, and thou art the Bábu'l-Báb, the gate of that Gate. Eighteen souls must, in the beginning, spontaneously and of their own accord, accept Me and recognize the truth of My Revelation. Unwarned and uninvited, each of these must seek independently to find Me. And when their number is complete, one of them must needs be chosen to accompany Me on My pilgrimage to Mecca and Medina. There I shall deliver the Message of God to the Sharíf of Mecca. I then shall return to Kúfih, where again, in the mosque of that holy city, I shall manifest His Cause. It is incumbent upon you not to divulge, either to your companions or to any other soul, that which you have seen and heard.”

This glorious Revelation filled Mullá Ḥusayn's soul with excitement and joy, with awe and wonder. “How feeble and impotent, how dejected and timid, I had felt previously!” he later said. “Then I could neither write nor walk, so tremulous were my hands and feet. Now, however, the knowledge of His Revelation had galvanized my being. I felt possessed of such courage and power that were the world, all its peoples and its potentates, to rise against me, I would, alone and undaunted, withstand their onslaught. The universe seemed but a handful of dust in my grasp. I seemed to be the Voice of Gabriel personified, calling unto all mankind: ‘Awake, for, lo! the morning Light has broken. Arise, for His Cause is made manifest. The portal of His grace is open wide; enter therein, O peoples of the world! For He Who is your promised One is come!’

The Declaration of the Báb took place on the eve of 23 May 1844. He was twenty five years old. Decades later, on the occasion of the anniversary of the Báb's Declaration, ‘Abdu'l-Bahá addressed those gathered in the following words:

**“This is 23 May, the anniversary of the message and Declaration of the Báb. It is a blessed day and the dawn of manifestation, for the appearance of the Báb was the early light of the true morn, . . . it is a blessed day, the inception of the heavenly bounty, the beginning of the divine effulgence. On this day in 1844 the Báb was sent forth heralding and proclaiming the Kingdom of God, announcing the glad tidings of the coming of Bahá'u'lláh and withstanding the opposition of the whole Persian nation.”<sup>5</sup>**